

The Walking Program

Nature's Back Balm

You Can Turn Walking into a Cure

When we think of the word “balm” we think of a wax or a cream that can be applied to the body that can eliminate a number of discomforts, from chapped lips to muscle aches. We think of it as something that can be reapplied throughout the day to continue to provide comfort and relief. Although no such topical concoction exists for back pain, each of us has the capacity to apply our own sort of “back balm” through an activity that is incredibly natural but underutilized by many: walking.

Walking is one of the most commonplace and fundamental activities inherent in our daily living. While simple to do, it is extremely and uniquely important for back health. A walking program needs to be a mandatory component of your pain elimination program, plain and simple.

Scientifically speaking, with each step, the act of lifting and swinging the leg requires muscular activity to support the pelvis from sinking down on one side and bending the spine. Each step produces gentle muscle contraction, which is repeated producing the gait pattern. Very few activities challenge the lateral parts of the spine and core, and trim the hips, as well as walking. The torso becomes an energy storage system, as with each step, elastic tissues in the back reduce the muscular effort, and unload the spine. This “unloading” is further assisted with arm swing and a faster walking speed. The torso sling muscles convey the arm movements and forces into drivers for the hips. In this way, walking trains essential muscular slings that contribute to other important activities in a way that eliminates back pain.

Some of you reading this may be confused, as you have found walking to increase your pain. You may have previously been given poor advice. It is likely you were told that walking slowly and leisurely would reduce your pain, but in doing just that you haven't experienced any relief. This is usually because walking too slowly actually statically loads the spine. The muscles add more crushing forces to the spine. On top of that, poor posture while walking will only worsen the pain. So our plan is to first correct

the walking posture to reduce strain on the painful parts, and then create a healthy walking pattern to eliminate pain.

In contrast to slow walking or “mall strolling”, moving more briskly usually changes walking from a cause of pain to a pain reliever. If you find that even a quickly paced walk hurts, either your pain sensitivity must be particularly high at this point in your recovery, or you are trying to walk too far in one session. This simply means that you may have to wait until you are further along before you add this component into your routine. In the meantime, follow the process outlined in the previous chapters, and eventually you will obtain relief with faster walking.

Other negative issues with the slow walk include the tendency to not swing your arms, further adding to the static muscle cramp. It is also common to lock the knee in full extension with each step. This removes the spring action of the leg muscles needed for pain-free walking.

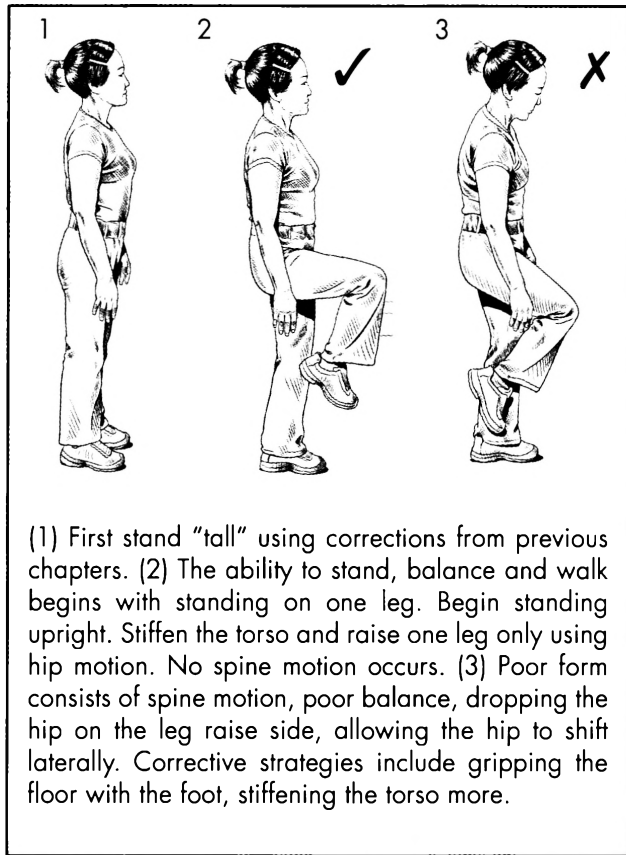
We've established that a faster pace is crucial, but other postural components are equally as important in perfecting a therapeutic walk. Pavel Tsatsouline, the Russian strongman makes interesting distinctions between cultural groups and how they walk. He claims that Americans generally look down at the ground while walking causing them to lead with their head cocked forwards. In contrast, Russians generally lead with their chest. This naturally promotes arm swing. This is the goal!

Walking with a Pain-Free Style

Observe your walking style in front of a mirror, a shop front window or have a friend take a video of you on their smart phone. Are you chin-poking, walking without swinging the arms or taking small steps? Are you looking down like the American? Or do you have a puffed out walk like the Russian? Be aware of your current style, then try the following corrections (see pics):

1. Achieve the corrected upright standing posture you have found to relieve pain. This will also prevent back muscle cramping.

2. Lightly stiffen the abdominal muscles.
3. Try a few marching steps. This means moving strongly and deliberately but in one place, lifting the knees slightly higher than you usually would.
4. Begin walking, swinging the arms about the shoulders - not the elbows. Recall the walking figure in Chapter 8.
5. Progress with larger and faster steps, until you establish a walk that “means business.” Move like you have somewhere to be.



How to Build a Pain-Free Walking Program

Some of you with high pain sensitivity will need to begin the walking program with short bursts performed on a frequent basis. If, for example, you experience pain after walking say ten steps, the logical rehab protocol is to take six to eight steps every hour on the hour. You do not have the pain-free ability at the present time to train with a professional – you will break into pain with every activity. Your goal is to work on your own to increase your ability to move without pain, and increase the volume of work you are able to perform pain-free.

This is the rationale behind interval training: training sessions are organized to slowly and methodically increase tolerance to pain. Through hourly walks, you will gain the number of steps that can be taken pain-free. As you continue to progress, the time between training sessions is also increased. Slowly, and methodically, you will reach the ultimate goal, which is to walk for half an hour three times per day – before breakfast, around midday and after dinner.

During this period in which you are continuing to lengthen your walks, you will likely benefit from taking “micro-breaks”. A micro-break essentially involves pausing in the middle of your walk to rest and check in with your posture. The truth is, people often lose their walking “good form” as they fatigue. If pain is impending, stop walking. Perform the drill to realign the lumbar spine and hips into the pain-free posture you learned in chapter 8. Clinicians call it “elastic equilibrium”, you call it your “sweet spot” position. This can be done at a park bench, perhaps stopping to briefly chat with someone. Now resume walking, enjoying the relief! We will further discuss this spine-sparing concept when looking at stenosis-specific recovery in chapter 14.

Once successful here you will graduate to enjoying longer walks. At this point, not only will you have attained success in increasing your walking mobility but you will also find that your abilities to perform other enjoyable activities have increased as well!

Progressing the Walking Program

Once you have found success with the daily walking prescription of 30 minutes three times per day, try a longer walk. Make note of how you feel the next day, as your body will be telling you whether or not you are ready for this step. Once you have experienced several pain-free weeks that include some longer walks, you may want to try a slow, short jog. If this feels good, repeat your jog for the next three days, after which you must take five days off. You may continue your walks, but rest from the jogs. It is noteworthy at this point to state that jogging is not necessary for back health, I simply mention it for those wishing to resume this activity if it is their goal. The trick is to stimulate the tissues to heal and gristle while not allowing the cumulative trauma to get ahead of the healing. If you want to work jogging into your schedule more permanently, take a week off every two to three weeks. This is the key to long term success.

Walking up or down an incline can be your friend or foe. Progressions for walking should eventually include walking up hill, on a gradual slope to begin with. Then try walking backwards uphill, with mindful focus on extending and pushing with the knees. Try lifting your arms overhead to foster a more upright, backwards walking posture. You will experience the leg training and know that you have done some good work.

As you can see, walking, like any other exercise for a back patient must begin slowly and build up to a more challenging level day by day. Pushing yourself to a point where you begin to experience pain is not a sign you need to drive through it, but rather that you need to stop, and build a smaller set of daily goals for yourself tomorrow. Yes, it takes patience, but good things come to those who wait.